cons and accepted our decision. For some unspecified reasons, the Agreemo kept getting delayed, I have my suspicions of it having been done deliberately, so it was not until June 2007 that we finally moved to Myanmar, more than six months later than planned, by which time Amala had already entered the twelfth grade.

In 2006, the military government in Myanmar abruptly shifted the capital from Yangon to Naypyitaw, a greenfield complex about 300 km to the North of Yangon. The move caught everyone by surprise, as almost overnight, all ministries and their staff were relocated. All the embassies, though, continued to function from Yangon, although a separate diplomatic zone exists in the Naypyitaw master plan. The Indian Embassy at Yangon is located on Merchant Street in downtown Yangon and is housed in what were the offices of the erstwhile Oriental Life Assurance Company, founded in Calcutta in 1818. The embassy moved into the premises in May 1957, where it has continued since then. The ambassador's residence, India House, on Taw Win Road, Dagon Township, housed the chief agent of the Imperial Bank of India until its rebirth as the nationalized State Bank of India in 1954. Most of the officers, including the Defence Attaché, stay in a small walled-off compound that once used to house the officials of the Burmah Shell company.

The Defence Wing was on the first floor of the embassy building. In addition to the DA, the other staff comprised a JCO (Clerk) and a Hav (PA). Col Chopra showed me around the embassy, introducing me to the Ambassador, Shri Bhaskar Mitra; the councillor, Shri Manoj Bharti; and the first secretary, Shri Raj Srivatsav.[1] He also took me to meet various officers of the Myanmar Army (MA). At Yangon, this was Col San Nyunt Oo, the liaison officer of their equivalent of the MI (FD). We then went to Naypyitaw where we called on the top

Copyright © Penguin Random House India
Not for circulation